into the city, turning the former Durrani winter capital into a massive Punjabi barracks. In the process the Sikh Khalsa had destroyed many of Peshawar's most beautiful sights. An enormous new brick fort had been built over the delicate pleasure gardens and pavilions of the Bala Hisar where Shah Shuja had in 1809 received the Elphinstone mission. Another new fort bristling with artillery had just been erected at Jamrud at the mouth of the Khyber. Burnes recorded that one of Ranjit Singh's former Napoleonic officers, Paolo Avitabile, now governed Peshawar, 'and the Sikhs had changed everything: many of the fine gardens around the town had been converted into cantonments; trees had been cut down; and the whole neighbourhood was one vast camp. Mahommedan usages have disappeared – the sounds of dancing and music were heard at all hours and all places.'[36]

Burnes also noted that, despite the massive army of occupation garrisoning the Peshawar valley, the Sikhs had found it very difficult to rule the rebellious Pashtuns who inhabited the area and that there had been so many tribal uprisings, assassinations and acts of insurrection in and around the city that the occupation of Peshawar had become a major drain on Sikh resources. This, he realised, was actually good news for his mission, as it could only make Ranjit Singh more willing to come to an accommodation with Dost Mohammad about the future of the city, and with luck allow Burnes to reconcile the two rivals, bringing both into alliance with the British.

The decision to send Burnes back to Kabul had been taken by the new Governor General, Lord Auckland, who had been alarmed by MacNeill's reports of the Russians' growing activity in Persia and their purported ambitions towards Herat and the rest of Afghanistan. Auckland had only just arrived in Calcutta and knew very little about the region, but he had met Burnes at a houseparty at Bowood during the latter's triumphant book tour two years earlier and assumed he was a safe pair of hands. So Burnes was sent off up the Indus for the second time, this time with instructions to make a more comprehensive study of the river, laying down buoys and erecting navigational landmarks. He was then to head on to Kabul, instructed to gather intelligence on 'the recently created ties between the rulers of the Afghan principalities and Persia', on the attitude of the Afghan population towards Russia and on Russian activity in the region and 'the measures